sister. The famous dialogue between Yama and Yami refers to a brother-sister love affair.[1] The Aitareya-Brāhamaṇa also refers to incestuous relations between the mother and son.[2]

Sarkar, taking his stand on the dialogue between Yama and Yami, the episode of Prajāpati's incest with his daughter as narrated in the Brāhamaṇas and in the Vedas, maintains that incestuous relations between brother and sister, father and daughter, as well as between mother and son were not uncommon. But why should great saints and sages indulge in these? And how, ethically, can they?

UNCONTROLLED SEXUAL PASSION

Vyāsa, the legendary compiler of the great epic was himself progeny of unwed love. His mother, Matsyagandha, as the epic narrates, was the foster daughter of a fisherman, and she rowed her father's ferry boat from one shore of the Ganges to the other. Once, sage Parasara happened to be a passenger on her ferry boat. The fair fisherwoman attracted the attention of the sage at once, and soon a desire to enjoy her arose in his mind. He accordingly expressed his desire. Matsyagandha refused him on the plea that she was ashamed of cohabiting in public with so many people on both shores looking upon them. But the sage at once created a mist round the boat so that nobody could see them. Wonderstruck at this miracle, the maiden spoke again, "Know me to be a maiden, O brilliant one, under the protection of my father. My maidenhood would lapse by your contact; how, then, shall I be able to return home? I shall not be able to stay at my father's house hereafter. Consider all this first, and then act as you like." The girl was relieved of her fear by a promise on the part of the sage that her maidenhood would be restored to her after intercourse. The sage further undertook to grant Matsyagandha any boon she cared to ask. Accordingly, Matsyagandha expressed the desire that a sweet perfume emanate from her body. The sage granted it, and the intercourse between the two took place on the boat. As a result of the union, Matsyagandha, now also known as Yojanagandha because of the pleasing odor emanating for miles around from her body, at once gave birth to a child called Dvaipayana whom she cast off on an island (Dvipa).[3] In the same Parva when Matsyagandha (as Satyavati) narrates this episode to Bhisma, she says that she agreed to the proposal of Parasara because she was afraid of a curse if she refused him. She also states that the child born out of the union was cast off by her on the island as the sage instructed so that she might be a virgin again.